

leagues in Hong Kong, Malaysia, and Thailand for the sake of earning \$1,000 or \$2,000. They lack the quality to secure spots in top leagues in Germany or the Netherlands, so they settle for these smaller competitions. Unfortunately, this stagnates their growth, and they fail to progress further.

But why are young players moving to these smaller leagues? At a time when India is reviving its love for hockey, what is holding Pakistan back?

The main issue is a lack of proper patronage. Hockey is our national sport, yet it is not part of the national budget. Players are aware that there are no secure jobs, and since we play only two or three international tournaments a year, the financial incentives are minimal. This uncertainty pushes them towards leagues in Hong Kong or Malaysia, where they can at least earn a living.

Unless we streamline our system and establish a Centre of Excellence, revival seems difficult. Despite once dominating the sport, we have fallen behind — disconnected from major leagues and global events. Our

physical fitness levels are also not on par with international standards. Collectively, these factors have left us trailing far behind.

India has revived hockey in recent years. What do you think has driven this turnaround?

The state of Odisha has made massive investments in Indian hockey, which is remarkable. In Pakistan, the interest simply isn't there. It's not just about funding — it's about prioritising the sport.

India will also benefit from the relaunch of the Hockey India League earlier this year. Their women's team has broken into the world's top four, while the men's team competes in the Pro League and has won medals at the Olympics and World Cup. India has embraced hockey professionally, and once a structured system is in place, a strong talent pipeline naturally develops.

With financial backing, India has hired top coaches at various levels, and the players have reaped the rewards. Crucially, every Indian player competes in around 40-50 matches annually, boosting confidence and teamwork.

Meanwhile, our cycle has stalled. Even if we secure the same level of funding as India, it will take at least five years to rebuild. The first challenge is bringing young players back, refining their skills, and preparing them for top-tier competition against teams like the Netherlands, Belgium, and Germany.

If you look at our players' statistics, their ball possession and touch rates barely exceed 10-15 minutes across three or four tournaments. That's simply not enough for players aiming to compete at the highest level.

Hockey India is led by former captain Dilip Tirkey. You were once part of the Pakistan Hockey Federation. Should Pakistan bring in an ex-player to lead its hockey administration?

The real issue is that we never built a proper system. We couldn't even plan a fixed calendar — whether the team would travel to Europe or elsewhere remained uncertain. Without a steady flow of funds and a structured process, it's impossible to move forward.

Revival is difficult because hockey